

THE COMPACT PLAYBOOK

Claude × Microsoft.

Four add-ins, one AI layer across the tools you already use — Excel, PowerPoint, Word and Outlook.

26 sections

plain, practical

copy-paste prompts

SECTION 01

Requirements & Access

What you need before installing anything

Plan requirements

All four add-ins require a paid Claude plan. The Free plan does not activate any of them.

PLAN	EXCEL	POWERPOINT	WORD	OUTLOOK
Pro (\$20/mo)	Yes	Yes	Yes (beta)	Yes (beta)
Max	Yes	Yes	Yes (beta)	Yes (beta)
Team	Yes	Yes	Yes (beta)	Yes (beta)
Enterprise	Yes	Yes	Yes (beta)	Yes (beta)
Free	No	No	No	No

Tip. Word and Outlook are currently in beta. Features and limits may change. They are production-ready for most work but expect occasional rough edges.

Version requirements

APP	WEB	WINDOWS	MAC	IPAD/ANDROID
Excel	Yes	M365 sub, build 16.0.13127+	v16.46+	iPad: Yes / Android: No
PowerPoint	Yes	M365 sub, build 16.0.13127+	v16.46+	Neither
Word	Yes	M365, Version 2205+	v16.61+	Neither
Outlook	Yes	New + classic Outlook, M365 sub	M365 sub	Neither

Warning. Perpetual/volume-licensed Office (2016, 2019) is not supported for any of the four add-ins. You need an active Microsoft 365 subscription.

What you need

- Active Microsoft 365 subscription (Business or Personal)
- Paid Claude plan — Pro, Max, Team, or Enterprise
- Internet connection during use (all add-ins call Anthropic servers)
- Office desktop app or Office on the web — mobile not supported
- For Outlook cross-mailbox features: one-time IT admin Graph consent (Section 04)

SECTION 02

Installing the Add-ins

Individual setup for each of the four tools

Excel, PowerPoint, and Word — one listing, three add-ins

Excel, PowerPoint, and Word share a single Microsoft Marketplace listing. One install covers all three.

Step-by-step (Excel, PowerPoint, Word)

1. Go to marketplace.microsoft.com and search for "Claude by Anthropic for Excel" — or go directly to the Claude for Microsoft 365 listing. 2. Click Get it now. Sign in with your Microsoft account if prompted. 3. Open Excel (or PowerPoint or Word). Go to Home → Add-ins (Windows) or Tools → Add-ins (Mac). 4. Find Claude in your installed add-ins and click Activate. 5. The Claude sidebar appears on the right of your screen. 6. Sign in with your Claude account (same credentials as claude.ai). First time only. 7. You are ready. Open any file and start typing in the sidebar.

Tip. Keyboard shortcut: Ctrl+Alt+C (Windows) or Ctrl+Option+C (Mac) opens Claude in Excel, PowerPoint, or Word.

Outlook — separate listing, one extra step

Outlook uses a separate Marketplace listing and needs Microsoft Graph consent before cross-mailbox features work.

Step-by-step (Outlook)

1. Go to marketplace.microsoft.com and search for "Claude by Anthropic for Outlook". 2. Click Get it now. 3. Open Outlook. Open any email. 4. Click the Claude button in the message ribbon. 5. Sign in with your Claude account. 6. For inbox triage, search, and scheduling: your IT admin must grant Microsoft Graph consent (Section 04). Without this, per-email features work but cross-mailbox features do not. 7. Pin the Claude task pane so it stays open as you move between messages.

Tip. Pin the Claude pane in Outlook: right-click the Claude button in the ribbon and select Pin. This keeps it open as you switch between emails without re-clicking each time.

Supported file formats

APP	SUPPORTED	NOT SUPPORTED
Excel	.xlsx, .xlsm	.xls, .csv (convert first)
PowerPoint	.pptx	.ppt (convert first)
Word	.docx	.doc (convert first)
Outlook	All mail + .docx, .xlsx, .pptx, .pdf inline	—

SECTION 03

Working Across All Four Apps

How Claude moves between Excel, PowerPoint, Word, and Outlook

What cross-app means

When all four add-ins are installed and cross-app is enabled, Claude can read from one open file and write to another — without you copying and pasting. Context follows the task.

- Analyse a financial model in Excel and generate a summary deck in PowerPoint from the same session.
- Read an email attachment in Outlook and open the attached Excel model with the thread already loaded as context.
- Pull numbers from an Excel workbook into a Word memo without switching apps.
- Summarise a Word document into PowerPoint slides in a single conversation.

How to enable cross-app

For individual users (Pro/Max) — on by default

1. Install all four add-ins. Activate each at least once. 2. In any add-in sidebar, go to Settings. 3. Toggle "Let Claude work across files" on. 4. Repeat in each add-in. 5. Connected file indicators appear in the sidebar showing linked files.

For Team/Enterprise (admin must enable first)

1. Admin goes to Organization settings → Office agents at claude.ai/admin-settings/office-agents. 2. Toggle "Let Claude work across apps" on. 3. Individual users can then toggle it in their own add-in settings.

Skills carry across apps

Skills you have enabled in your Claude settings apply automatically across all four add-ins. A Skill that enforces your modeling conventions activates in Excel; a Skill that matches your slide template activates in PowerPoint. Type / in any sidebar to see Skills available for that app.

Current limitations

- Claude can only read from and write to files that are currently open. It cannot open, close, or switch files itself.
- Cross-app chat history is not saved between sessions.
- All four add-ins must be installed and the setting toggled on in each.

SECTION 04

Enterprise & IT Admin Setup

Deploying to your organisation through Microsoft 365 Admin Center

Method 1: Admin Center deployment (recommended)

Deploy Excel, PowerPoint, and Word

1. Go to admin.microsoft.com and sign in as admin. 2. Navigate to Settings → Org Settings → User owned apps and services. 3. Ensure "Let users access the Office Store" is toggled on. 4. Go to Settings → Integrated apps → Add-ins. 5. Search for "Claude by Anthropic for Excel" in Microsoft AppSource. 6. Select Deploy and choose scope: entire organisation, specific users, or groups. 7. Click Deploy. Appears in users' Home ribbon within minutes (up to 24 hours for full rollout). 8. Users will see Claude in their ribbon and sign in with their Claude accounts on first use.

Deploy Outlook

1. Go to admin.microsoft.com → Settings → Integrated apps → Add-ins. 2. Search for "Claude by Anthropic for Outlook". 3. Deploy to target users or groups. 4. Complete the Microsoft Graph consent step below — without it, cross-mailbox features will not work.

Method 2: Manifest XML (for orgs with Office Store disabled)

Download the manifest XML files and upload them via Admin Center when the Office Store is disabled for your organisation.

Excel: pivot.claude.ai/manifest-excel.xml

PowerPoint: pivot.claude.ai/manifest-powerpoint.xml

Word: pivot.claude.ai/manifest-word.xml

Outlook: pivot.claude.ai/manifest-outlook.xml

1. Download the manifest XML for each add-in you are deploying. 2. Go to admin.microsoft.com → Settings → Integrated apps. 3. Click Upload custom apps → Office Add-in → I have a manifest file on this device. 4. Browse and select the manifest file. Click Upload. 5. Assign users. Click Deploy.

Outlook only: Microsoft Graph consent

Warning. Without this step, inbox triage, mailbox search, and scheduling in Claude for Outlook will not work. Every user will see a "Need admin approval" message until completed.

A Global Administrator must grant tenant-wide consent for Mail.ReadWrite, Calendars.Read, People.Read, User.Read, and offline_access as delegated scopes. The Graph access token stays in the browser's MSAL cache — it is never sent to Anthropic.

1. Have a Global Admin open the admin consent URL provided in your Anthropic onboarding materials in a browser signed in to your Microsoft 365 tenant. 2. The admin sees a Microsoft permissions screen listing the five scopes. 3. The admin clicks Accept. Consent takes effect immediately for all users. 4. No further Microsoft prompts will appear for any user after this.

LLM gateway – using Claude without individual accounts

If your organisation routes API traffic through an internal LLM gateway connected to Amazon Bedrock, Google Cloud Vertex AI, or Microsoft Azure, all four add-ins can be used without individual Claude accounts. Same gateway pattern as Claude Code. See Use Claude for Microsoft 365 with third-party platforms in the Anthropic support docs.

SECTION 05

Safety, Data & Limitations

What to know before using these add-ins with real work

How your data is handled

- Inputs and outputs are automatically deleted from Anthropic's backend within 30 days.
- Chat history is stored locally in your browser (IndexedDB) – not on Anthropic servers, not synced across devices.
- Clearing your browser data clears your add-in chat history.
- Each add-in has its own separate chat history: Excel, PowerPoint, Word, and Outlook histories do not mix.
- Claude can only access the file you currently have open. It cannot browse your file system.

Warning. On Pro, Max, and Team plans, audit logs, the Compliance API, and data export features are not available for the add-ins. Enterprise organisations can route audit telemetry to an OTEL collector, but add-in activity is not in standard Enterprise audit logs at this time.

What these add-ins are NOT suitable for

Do not use for... Why

HIPAA / PHI data or patient records No HIPAA BAA in place for add-ins

PCI / payment card information Compliance requirements not met

SOX, GDPR, or audit-critical workflows No audit log coverage in add-ins

Final client deliverables without human review AI makes mistakes; always review before sending

Unreviewed outbound email (Outlook) Claude never sends — all drafts land unsent

Counterparty files or external templates Prompt injection risk from untrusted content

Prompt injection – the risk to know

All four add-ins read content from files. Malicious instructions hidden in spreadsheet cells, document text, email bodies, or attachments can trick Claude into taking unintended actions.

- A spreadsheet downloaded from the internet may contain hidden cell instructions to export your data.
- A contract from a counterparty may have hidden text instructing Claude to modify terms.
- An inbound email may contain instructions to forward threads or draft replies you did not request.

Warning. Only use these add-ins with files from trusted internal sources. Do not load vendor templates, counterparty files, or downloaded spreadsheets in Claude without reviewing their content first.

Claude for Excel

The AI layer for financial models, data analysis, and spreadsheet work

SECTION 06

What Claude for Excel Is

The add-in for professionals who live in spreadsheets

What it is

Claude for Excel puts Claude directly inside Microsoft Excel. It reads your workbook — formulas, tabs, dependencies, errors — and works on it the way a senior analyst would. Describe what you need, Claude reads what is there, makes the changes, explains what it did, and cites every cell it touched.

Who it is built for

Financial analysts and FP&A teams

Building models, running scenarios, checking variance. Claude reads multi-tab financial models and maintains formula dependencies when updating assumptions.

Investment bankers and PE analysts

Three-statement models, LBO schedules, DCF templates, deal comparables. Claude understands IB modeling conventions and applies standard formatting.

Operations and strategy teams

Unit economics, capacity plans, tracking dashboards. Claude categorises transactions, cleans data, and builds summaries.

Finance and ops managers

Expense reports, budget trackers, MIS dashboards. Claude handles the repetitive assembly work.

Anyone who uses Excel

If you get stuck on formulas, errors, or formatting, Claude explains what is wrong and fixes it.

SECTION 07

Getting Around Claude for Excel

The interface, navigation, and shortcuts

The interface

Claude opens as a sidebar panel on the right side of Excel. The rest of Excel stays fully functional. You type in the sidebar, Claude responds there, and all changes appear in your workbook — highlighted so you can see exactly what moved.

Opening Claude for Excel

METHOD	HOW
Keyboard shortcut (Windows)	Ctrl+Alt+C
Keyboard shortcut (Mac)	Ctrl+Option+C
From the ribbon (Windows)	Home → Add-ins → Claude
From the ribbon (Mac)	Tools → Add-ins → Claude
From Insert tab	Insert → My Add-ins → Claude

Tip. If the sidebar fails to load, click any ribbon dropdown and select Refresh. This is a known intermittent issue and the refresh always fixes it.

The sidebar layout

- Chat input at the bottom — type your request here
- Conversation history above — scroll up to see earlier turns
- Settings (gear icon) — instructions, connectors, session logging
- Connectors icon — link external tools like Google Drive or Notion
- Type / to see available Skills for Excel
- Model selector — switch Claude models mid-session

Persistent instructions

Open Settings and fill in the Instructions field. These apply to every conversation in Excel. Set your formatting standards once and never repeat them.

EXAMPLE INSTRUCTIONS

Always use IB formatting: blue inputs (RGB 0,112,255), black formula outputs. Use commas for thousands and two decimal places for percentages. When building models, link all inputs to a dedicated Inputs tab. Never hardcode values inside formulas.

Session logging

Toggle session logging in Settings. Claude creates a Claude Log tab in your workbook tracking every action it takes per turn. Useful for auditing changes in complex models.

Change tracking

Claude highlights every cell it updates. Use Excel's standard Undo (Ctrl+Z / Cmd+Z) to revert anything you disagree with. Claude warns before overwriting existing data.

SECTION 08

Key Features in Depth

What Claude for Excel can actually do

Read and understand complex models

Claude reads your entire open workbook — all tabs, all formulas, all dependencies. Ask it to explain the model first before editing anything. Answers come with cell-level citations you can click through to the exact cells referenced.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What assumptions drive the revenue forecast in Q3?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Explain how the WACC flows through the DCF"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Walk me through how the three statements connect"

Update assumptions safely

Change values and inputs while Claude maintains all formula dependencies. Every change is highlighted with a clear explanation. Claude will not overwrite formulas with hardcoded values unless you explicitly ask.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Increase growth rate by 2% and show the impact on terminal value"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Update interest rate assumptions to 6.5% across all periods"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Change the exit multiple from 12x to 10x and rebuild the returns table"

Build and fill templates

Create spreadsheets from scratch or populate existing templates. Claude builds to your structure, uses your stated conventions, and formats to your standards.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Build a three-statement financial model for a SaaS company"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Fill this DCF template with data from the uploaded 10-K"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Create a SaaS metrics model tracking ARR, churn, and LTV"

Debug and fix errors

Claude identifies #REF!, #VALUE!, circular references, and broken links, traces them to the root cause, and proposes fixes that preserve spreadsheet integrity.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Find all #REF and #VALUE errors in this workbook"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Why is cell B4 showing #VALUE? Trace the issue"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Identify and fix all circular references"

Edit and format natively

Claude applies Excel-native operations directly: sorting, filtering, pivot table edits, conditional formatting, data validation, print setup. These are actual Excel operations landing in your file.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Sort this table by revenue, descending"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Apply conditional formatting: highlight anything below target in red"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Set up a dropdown for Status with options: Active, Pending, Closed"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Apply IB formatting across all input cells in this model"

Data analysis and insights

Claude reads patterns, calculates variances, and categorises data. For large transaction datasets or multi-year financials, it surfaces what is worth paying attention to.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What trends stand out in 2025 vs 2024?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Compare actuals to budget and explain the largest variances"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Categorise these transactions into expense types"

Document import and extraction

Claude extracts tables from uploaded PDFs directly into your spreadsheet and maps imported CSV data to your standard format.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Extract the financial table from this PDF into Excel"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Map the imported CSV data to my standard format"

Connectors – context from other tools

Connect external tools through the connectors panel. Claude draws on linked sources when building or refining models.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Pull the latest ARR figures from our CRM into this model"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Load the Q2 actuals from the linked Google Drive report"

SECTION 09

10 Use Cases with Starter Prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Claude for Excel

1. Build a financial model from scratch

FOR For any analyst starting a new engagement

STARTER PROMPT

Build a three-statement financial model for a B2B SaaS company. Include an Inputs tab with all assumptions (ARR growth, gross margin, headcount, capex). Income statement, balance sheet, and cash flow should link automatically. Add a Scenarios tab with base, bull, and bear cases. Use IB formatting: blue for inputs, black for formulas.

2. Debug a broken model you inherited

FOR For anyone handed an unfamiliar spreadsheet

STARTER PROMPT

This model has errors and I am not sure why. Read every tab. Identify all #REF, #VALUE, and circular reference errors. For each one, trace it to the root cause and explain what broke. Fix them one by one. Highlight every cell you touch. Give me a summary of what was wrong.

3. Run a scenario analysis

FOR For FP&A and strategy teams stress-testing assumptions

STARTER PROMPT

Add three scenarios to this model: base (current assumptions), downside (revenue -15%, costs +5%), upside (revenue +20%, costs flat). Link all scenarios to the same Inputs tab with a dropdown selector. Build a Scenarios Summary tab showing key metrics side-by-side for each case.

4. Clean and structure messy data

FOR For ops teams working with raw exports

STARTER PROMPT

Look at the data in the Raw Data tab. Fix date formats to YYYY-MM-DD. Remove duplicate rows keeping the most recent. Standardise the Region column: all entries should be North, South, East, or West. Split full name into First Name and Last Name. Flag rows you could not clean automatically.

5. Build a dashboard from existing sheets

FOR For finance managers preparing board materials

STARTER PROMPT

Read all sheets in this workbook. Build a new Executive Dashboard tab with: total revenue YTD vs budget with variance %, gross margin trend chart, headcount by department, and top 5 variances by line item. Use chart types appropriate for each metric. Apply consistent formatting.

6. Analyse variances and write commentary

FOR For monthly close and reporting teams

STARTER PROMPT

Compare the Actuals tab to the Budget tab. Identify the 10 largest variances by absolute value. For each one: explain the likely cause based on the data, flag whether it is a timing issue or a real miss, and write one-line commentary. Format the output as a table I can paste into a board report.

7. Fill a template from uploaded data

FOR For anyone populating a standard format repeatedly

STARTER PROMPT

I have attached a PDF of a quarterly earnings release. Extract all financial figures: revenue, gross profit, operating income, EBITDA, EPS, and guidance for next quarter. Populate the template on the Earnings tab with these numbers. Highlight anything you could not find with a note explaining what is missing.

8. Write and explain formulas

FOR For anyone stuck on a formula or learning Excel

STARTER PROMPT

Look at the Billing tab. I need a formula that: calculates days overdue for each invoice (Due Date vs today), returns zero for paid invoices, and flags anything over 90 days as CRITICAL in a separate column. Explain each formula in plain English after writing it.

9. Consolidate multiple sheets

FOR For monthly reporting across regions or entities

STARTER PROMPT

I have five regional sheets: North, South, East, West, International. Each has the same structure. Build a Consolidated tab that sums all five using formulas (not pasted values) so it updates automatically. Add a check row confirming the consolidated total matches the sum of all regions.

10. Prepare a model for client delivery

FOR For analysts formatting final outputs

STARTER PROMPT

This model needs to be client-ready. Apply IB formatting: blue inputs, black formulas, green checks. Add a cover sheet with company name, date, and model version. Lock all formula cells so only input cells are editable. Hide all tabs except Cover, Inputs, and Summary. Set the print area on the Summary tab.

SECTION 10

Pro Tips, Troubleshooting & First 30 Minutes

Getting the most out of Claude for Excel

Pro tips

Ask Claude to read the model before editing it

Before any non-trivial change, ask Claude to explain the structure first. "Read this workbook and tell me how it is structured" before "refactor" produces dramatically better output.

Set persistent instructions once

Put your formatting standards and model conventions in the Instructions field. You will never have to repeat "use IB formatting" again.

Cite the cell when describing a problem

"Fix cell B14" is better than "fix the formula in the top section." Claude works faster with a precise starting point.

Turn on session logging for complex models

When Claude is making many changes, session logging creates an audit trail of exactly what happened in which order. Useful if you need to revert selectively.

Break big models into phases

Ask Claude to build each statement in a separate request for a full three-statement model. Review each phase before proceeding.

Describe the output format, not the steps

"Build a summary tab showing revenue by region with a waterfall chart" is more effective than step-by-step instructions. Describe the destination.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Add-in not in ribbon	Home → Add-ins → My Add-ins → Refresh. If absent, repair Office.
Sidebar fails to load	Click any ribbon dropdown and select Refresh.
Claude cannot see my data	Must be .xlsx or .xlsm. CSV and XLS are not supported – convert first.
Changes going to wrong cells	State the cell reference explicitly: "Update cell B4 in the Assumptions tab."
Formula errors after edits	Undo immediately, then ask Claude to explain the formula structure first.
Cannot sign in	Must be on a paid Claude plan. Free plan does not activate the add-in.

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Works on web but not desktop	Check Excel build: minimum 16.0.13127.20296. Update Microsoft 365.
Wrong assumptions every session	Add them to Instructions in Settings. They persist across all sessions.

Your first 30 minutes with Claude for Excel

Minutes 0-10: Setup and orientation

- Install the add-in and sign in.
- Open a real workbook from your actual work.
- Type in the sidebar: "Read this workbook and explain what it does."
- Ask follow-ups: "What are the key assumptions?" and "What are the biggest formula dependencies?"

Minutes 10-20: Set your instructions

- Open Settings → Instructions.
- Add 3-5 lines: formatting standard, naming convention, one thing Claude always gets wrong.
- Close and reopen. Ask Claude to summarise your instructions back to confirm.

Minutes 20-30: Make a real change

- Pick one concrete task: fix an error, add a scenario, build a summary tab.
- Describe it clearly. Include the output format in your description.
- Review Claude's changes before saving. Use Undo if anything looks wrong.
- Make a list of 3 real Excel tasks this week that Claude could handle.

Excel Quick Reference

THE MENTAL MODEL	SHORTCUTS & VERSIONS
Claude lives in a sidebar inside Excel.	Open (Windows): Ctrl + Alt + C
Describe what you need – Claude reads	Open (Mac): Ctrl + Option + C
the workbook, edits it, explains each	Supported: Web, Windows, Mac, iPad
change, and cites every cell it touched.	NOT supported: Android, Office 2016/19 Formats: .xlsx and .xlsm only Convert .xls/.csv before opening
WHAT IT CAN DO	WHAT IT CANNOT DO
Read multi-tab models with cell citations	Work with VBA, macros, or data tables
Update assumptions, preserve dependencies	Access files not currently open
Build and fill spreadsheet templates	Send or share data externally

THE MENTAL MODEL	SHORTCUTS & VERSIONS
Debug #REF, #VALUE, circular references	Replace financial judgment and review
Sort, filter, conditional format natively	Final client work without human review
Extract data from uploaded PDF files	Audit-critical calcs without verification

PROMPT FORMULA

[What you want: read / build / fix / update / analyse] + [Which cells, tabs, or ranges]
[Output format: table, chart, new tab, edited in place] + [Formatting standard]

HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS

- Write persistent Instructions: formatting standard, naming, model conventions – one setup, every session benefits
- Enable session logging for complex models – creates per-turn audit trail of exactly what Claude changed
- Ask Claude to read the model first, then edit – produces dramatically better output than jumping straight to changes

Claude for PowerPoint
The AI layer for slide decks, presentations, and visual communication

SECTION 11

What Claude for PowerPoint Is

The add-in for professionals who build presentations

What it is

Claude for PowerPoint integrates Claude directly into Microsoft PowerPoint. It reads your open deck — slides, layouts, template, and content — and builds, edits, and refines it. Changes land as native PowerPoint objects: editable shapes, charts, and text you can modify directly.

Who it is built for

Consultants and strategy teams

Client decks, board materials, market sizing, competitive landscapes. Claude understands consulting deck conventions.

Finance and investor relations teams

Board packs, investor presentations, earnings decks. Claude works with your financial data and converts it into clean visuals.

Product and marketing teams

Product roadmaps, go-to-market decks, pitch materials. Claude iterates fast on content so you spend time on thinking.

Managers and team leads

Internal presentations, project updates, team briefings. Claude handles the assembly so you focus on the story.

Anyone who builds decks

If PowerPoint is part of your work, Claude reduces the time from rough notes to slide-ready content.

SECTION 12

Getting Around Claude for PowerPoint

The interface, navigation, and template awareness

Opening Claude for PowerPoint

METHOD	HOW
Keyboard shortcut (Windows)	Ctrl+Alt+C
Keyboard shortcut (Mac)	Ctrl+Option+C
From the ribbon (Windows)	Home → Add-ins → Claude
From the ribbon (Mac)	Tools → Add-ins → Claude

Template awareness – the most important thing to know

Claude reads your deck's slide master: layouts, fonts, color scheme, and placeholder structure. When you ask it to generate or edit slides, it uses your template – not generic defaults. Always load your template before starting a Claude session.

Tip. Always open your template first, then start the Claude conversation. If you ask Claude to generate slides on a blank deck without a template, it will use generic defaults. Apply your template first and Claude reads the slide master automatically.

Persistent instructions

Instructions set for PowerPoint are separate from Excel instructions. Use this for brand guidelines and slide structure preferences.

EXAMPLE INSTRUCTIONS

Always use one-line bullets on content slides. Maximum 5 bullets per slide. Lead with the insight, not the data. Use the blue accent color for highlighted text. Every section should start with a so-what slide. No clip art or stock photos.

SECTION 13

Key Features in Depth

What Claude for PowerPoint can actually do

Build from your template

Describe what you need and Claude generates slides using your slide master — the correct layouts, fonts, and colors from your template.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Create a market sizing section: 3 slides covering TAM, SAM, SOM with supporting visuals"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Build a competitive landscape slide comparing our four main competitors"

Edit individual slides

Select a slide or specify a slide number. Claude makes targeted edits without touching surrounding slides.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Simplify the text on slide 3 — it is too dense"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Restructure the argument across slides 4-7 to lead with recommendations"

Generate full deck structures

Open a blank deck (with template applied) and describe your goal. Claude builds a complete draft with logical structure.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Create a 10-slide deck covering our Q3 results, what drove performance, and Q4 priorities"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Build a market entry deck: problem, market size, approach, evidence, team, ask"

Create native charts and diagrams

Convert bullet points into process flows, comparison matrices, or native editable PowerPoint charts. Not static images — editable objects.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Turn these four bullet points into a 2x2 matrix"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Create a bar chart comparing Q1-Q4 performance using the data in this slide"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Build a waterfall chart showing revenue bridge"

Iterate on reviewer feedback

Make changes to specific slides based on feedback without redoing the deck. Claude preserves formatting and template compliance across iterations.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"The partner said slide 4 is too busy. Reduce it to one key message."

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Combine slides 5 and 6 into a single summary"

Connectors – context from external tools

Connect Google Drive, Notion, or other tools to give Claude context beyond the open deck.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Use the product roadmap from our Notion workspace to populate slide 8"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Pull the Q3 sales data from the linked Excel model"

SECTION 14

10 Use Cases with Starter Prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Claude for PowerPoint

1. Build a client deck from a brief

FOR For consultants and strategy teams

STARTER PROMPT

I have loaded my firm's standard template. Build a 12-slide strategy deck for a market entry assessment. Structure: executive summary, problem statement, market sizing (TAM/SAM/SOM), competitive landscape, our recommended approach, evidence and case studies, risks and mitigations, team and timeline, and commercial ask. One key message per slide. Keep text minimal – visuals and data where possible.

2. Turn rough notes into a structured deck

FOR For anyone with ideas but no slide structure

STARTER PROMPT

I have notes in the chat below. Read them and build a deck that captures the key arguments clearly. Identify the 5-7 main points, decide the best order for them, and build one slide per point. Use my template. Write every slide headline as a complete insight, not a topic label.

3. Rebuild a dense slide

FOR For anyone told "your slides are too wordy"

STARTER PROMPT

Look at slide 4. It has 11 bullet points and is unreadable. Break it into 3 slides: the core insight, supporting evidence, and the implication. Rewrite the headlines as insights. Maximum 4 bullets per slide, maximum 8 words per bullet. Keep the same content, better structured.

4. Build a board presentation

FOR For finance and strategy teams presenting to leadership

STARTER PROMPT

Build a 10-slide board presentation covering Q2 results. Include: opening so-what summary, revenue vs plan with variance commentary, gross margin trend, top 3 strategic initiatives and status, the one thing that went wrong and how we are fixing it, and Q3 priorities with owners. Executive style — big numbers, minimal text.

5. Convert a Word document into slides

FOR For anyone who drafts in Word and needs to present it

STARTER PROMPT

I will paste the content of my Word document below. Read it and convert the key points into a 6-slide summary deck. Identify the narrative structure, decide what belongs on each slide, write punchy one-line headlines. Use my template.

6. Create a competitive landscape

FOR For strategy, product, and sales teams

STARTER PROMPT

Build a 3-slide competitive analysis section. Slide 1: a 2x2 positioning matrix (price vs capability). Slide 2: a feature comparison table for the top 5 competitors. Slide 3: our differentiation narrative in 3 bullets. Use the company names and features I describe below.

7. Build a process or timeline slide

FOR For project managers and ops teams

STARTER PROMPT

Create a visual timeline showing our product roadmap for the next 12 months. 4 quarters, 3 major milestones per quarter. Horizontal timeline format with milestone labels. Highlight Q2 milestones in the accent color. Keep each label to 5 words maximum.

8. Prepare a pitch deck

FOR For founders and BD teams

STARTER PROMPT

Build a 10-slide pitch deck: problem, solution, market size, product demo summary, business model, traction, competition, team, financials (revenue, ARR, gross margin), and ask. One message per slide. Write every headline as a statement. Use the data I provide below.

9. Audit a deck for quality

FOR For anyone preparing materials for senior leadership

STARTER PROMPT

Read all slides in this deck. For each slide: flag if the headline is a topic label instead of an insight (rewrite it), flag if there are more than 5 bullets (suggest which to cut), flag any jargon to simplify. Do not change anything yet — give me a slide-by-slide audit with specific recommendations.

10. Restructure an existing deck

FOR For anyone whose deck "does not quite work"

STARTER PROMPT

Read this deck. The story does not flow well. Propose a new slide order that builds the argument more logically. Show me the proposed order, explain why you moved things, and flag any slides to cut or merge. Once I approve the structure, apply the reorder.

SECTION 15

Pro Tips, Troubleshooting & First 30 Minutes

Getting the most out of Claude for PowerPoint

Pro tips

Load your template before anything else

Claude reads the slide master when you start. Open your template, activate Claude, then start. Blank deck = generic output.

Write headlines as insights, not topics

Tell Claude: "Every slide headline must be a complete sentence stating the key insight."
This one change improves deck quality significantly.

Target individual slides for edits

Claude can make surgical edits to specific slides without regenerating the deck.
"Simplify slide 7" is better than "simplify the dense parts."

Describe the audience

"Build for a sceptical CFO" produces different slides than "build for an internal team update." Tell Claude who will be in the room.

Review before distributing

Claude's output is a first draft. For client-facing decks, check every headline and verify every number before sending.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Claude not using my template	Apply template before opening Claude. Close and reopen sidebar.
Slides look generic	Load your template first. Check that slide master layouts have clear names.
Charts are static images	Ask explicitly: "Create a native editable PowerPoint chart."
Sidebar not loading	Click any ribbon dropdown → Refresh.
iPad not supported	Use PowerPoint on web or desktop.

Your first 30 minutes with Claude for PowerPoint

1. Open a presentation with your template already applied. 2. Type in the sidebar: "Read this deck and tell me the main argument it is making." 3. Ask: "Which slide headlines are topics instead of insights? List them." 4. Pick the worst slide. Ask Claude to rewrite the headline as a complete insight. 5. Review. Undo if needed. Ask Claude to try again with more specifics. 6. Add what Claude got wrong to Settings → Instructions.

PowerPoint Quick Reference

THE MENTAL MODEL	SHORTCUTS & VERSIONS
Claude lives in a sidebar inside PowerPoint.	Open (Windows): Ctrl + Alt + C
Describe the output – Claude reads your	Open (Mac): Ctrl + Option + C
template and builds slides using the	Supported: Web · Windows · Mac
correct layouts, fonts, and colors.	NOT supported: iPad · Android · Office 2016/19 CRITICAL: Load your template BEFORE starting
WHAT IT CAN DO	WHAT IT CANNOT DO
Build slides from your slide master template	Work on iPad or Android
Edit individual slides without touching others	Replace your judgment on narrative flow
Generate full deck structures from a brief	Guarantee brand compliance on complex templates

THE MENTAL MODEL	SHORTCUTS & VERSIONS
Convert bullets to native editable charts	Access files not currently open
Iterate on feedback without redoing the deck	Final client decks without human review
Read connectors for external context	

PROMPT FORMULA

[What you want: generate / edit / restructure / convert to visual] + [Which slides or whole deck]
[Audience and purpose: board deck · internal update · client pitch] + [Brand or formatting constraints]

HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS

Always apply your template before opening Claude — it reads the slide master and uses your layouts, fonts, and colors automatically
Set persistent Instructions: one-line bullets, slide structure preferences, accent color rules — pays off on every session
Write every headline as a complete insight sentence, not a topic label — tell Claude this once in Instructions and it applies everywhere

Claude for Word
The AI layer for legal review, document drafting, and precision editing

SECTION 16

What Claude for Word Is

The add-in for professionals who work with documents

What it is

Claude for Word (currently in beta) integrates Claude into Microsoft Word with capabilities built for document-heavy professional work: legal contract review, financial memo drafting, tracked-change editing, and iterative document refinement. Every edit Claude makes can land as a tracked revision in Word's native review pane — visible, reviewable, and individually acceptable or rejectable.

Who it is built for

Legal teams and lawyers

Contract review, redlining, tracking counterparty changes, drafting new provisions. Claude reads multi-level legal numbering, defined terms, and cross-references.

Investment bankers and analysts

Investment memos, CIM drafts, management presentations. Claude drafts in your document's heading and paragraph styles.

Consultants and strategy teams

Reports, proposals, deliverables. Claude edits in tracked-changes mode and works through reviewer comments systematically.

HR and operations teams

Policy documents, SOPs, templates. Claude fills templates in the correct style and finds inconsistent defined terms.

Anyone who writes professionally

If documents are part of your work, Claude accelerates from rough draft to finished output.

SECTION 17

Getting Around Claude for Word

The interface, tracked changes, and comment-driven editing

Opening Claude for Word

Claude for Word uses a separate Marketplace listing from Excel and PowerPoint. Search for "Claude by Anthropic for Word" on Microsoft Marketplace.

METHOD	HOW
From the ribbon (Windows)	Home → Add-ins → Claude
From the ribbon (Mac)	Tools → Add-ins → Claude
First time	Sign in with your Claude account when prompted

Tracked changes mode

Ask Claude to work in suggested edits mode and every edit lands as a tracked revision. Original text shows as a deletion, new text as an insertion. Accept or reject each revision individually in Word’s review pane. Nothing is applied without your review.

HOW TO ACTIVATE

Tell Claude: "Work in tracked changes mode" or "Make all edits as tracked revisions" at the start of your session.

Comment-driven editing

Claude reads every open comment thread, understands what text it is anchored to, edits the passage, and replies to the comment explaining what it changed. You clear comments as you accept changes.

Model selection

Claude for Word lets you choose between Opus 4.7, Opus 4.6, and Sonnet 4.6. For complex legal or financial documents, Opus 4.7 gives the best reasoning on dense material.

Persistent instructions

EXAMPLE INSTRUCTIONS

Use my firm's standard positions on indemnification and liability. Flag anything non-standard. When summarising, lead with commercial terms, then risk items, then administrative. Always use tracked changes when editing contracts. Keep defined terms consistent – flag if I use two names for the same concept.

SECTION 18

Key Features in Depth

What Claude for Word can actually do

Read and understand documents

Ask Claude questions about specific sections, clauses, or defined terms. Answers come with clickable citations that navigate to the referenced section. Understands multi-level legal numbering, cross-references, and standard contract structure.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What is the liability cap and is it mutual?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Summarise the key commercial terms"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Find every provision that touches data retention"

Edit selected text

Select a passage and tell Claude what to change. Claude edits only the selection, preserving surrounding styles, numbering, and formatting.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Tighten this paragraph and drop the passive voice"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Rewrite this clause to make the indemnification mutual"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Simplify this section for a non-technical audience"

Tracked changes mode

Every edit lands as a reviewable tracked revision. Original versus new, visible in Word's review pane. Individual accept or reject.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Rewrite clause 4.2 to cap damages at 12 months of fees, make it mutual, track all changes"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Draft a mutual indemnification clause after clause 8 as a tracked insertion"

Comment-driven editing

Claude reads all open comment threads and works through them. For each, it edits the anchored passage and replies explaining what it changed.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Work through all my open comments"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Address the comment on the liability section"

Summarise counterparty redlines

When a counterparty returns a document with tracked changes, Claude reads and summarises what they changed, grouped by severity.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Summarise what the other side changed and flag anything worth discussing"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Which of these redlines are dealbreakers?"

Fill templates

Draft sections using your document's heading and paragraph styles. Tables populate in place without reflowing layout.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Draft the Key Risks section with four risks in the template's style"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Populate the summary table with revenue, gross margin, and net retention for the last three years"

Semantic navigation

Find every provision or passage touching a specific theme. Thematic matches, not just keyword hits. Click each result to navigate.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Find every provision touching data retention"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Where does this agreement address termination?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Are there any inconsistencies in how the parties are named?"

Cross-app context

Claude for Word shares context with Excel, PowerPoint, and Outlook. Pull numbers from an open Excel model into a Word memo without switching apps.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Pull the Q3 revenue and margin figures from the open Excel model into section 2 of this memo"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Summarise this document into a 6-slide deck structure in PowerPoint"

SECTION 19

10 Use Cases with Starter Prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Claude for Word

1. Review a contract for commercial risks

FOR For legal teams, in-house counsel, and anyone signing agreements

STARTER PROMPT

Read this contract. Produce a one-page summary covering: parties and governing law, term and renewal, payment terms, scope of services, IP ownership, indemnification (is it mutual?), liability cap, and termination rights. Flag the 3 clauses I should push back on and explain why each one is non-standard.

2. Summarise counterparty redlines

FOR For anyone receiving a marked-up document

STARTER PROMPT

The counterparty returned this agreement with tracked changes. Read all tracked insertions and deletions. Group them into three categories: material changes (worth negotiating), minor changes (likely acceptable), and administrative changes (style, no substance). For each material change, tell me what they changed and whether I should push back.

3. Draft an investment memo section

FOR For investment analysts and finance teams

STARTER PROMPT

I need to write the Investment Thesis section for this memo. Use the three points below as the basis. Write in the style of the rest of this document (formal, analytical, active voice). Pull supporting figures from the open Excel model. Each point: the claim, the evidence, and the implication. Apply the memo's heading and paragraph styles.

4. Work through reviewer comments

FOR For anyone with a marked-up draft to address

STARTER PROMPT

There are 8 open comments in this document. Work through them in tracked changes mode. For each comment: edit the anchored text, reply to the thread explaining what you changed, and mark it resolved. If any comment is ambiguous, ask me to clarify before editing.

5. Rewrite a section for a different audience

FOR For anyone adapting content between technical and non-technical readers

STARTER PROMPT

Rewrite section 3 for a non-technical audience. The current version is written for lawyers. The new version should be readable by a business executive. Remove legal jargon and replace with plain English. Keep the same structure and substantive content. Track all changes.

6. Fill a template with new content

FOR For anyone populating a standard document format

STARTER PROMPT

I have loaded my standard board memo template. Draft the full memo using the information I provide below. Use the template's heading styles, table formats, and paragraph styles throughout. Populate every placeholder. For the summary table in section 1, pull the numbers from the open Excel model.

7. Audit a document for consistency

FOR For editors doing a final QA pass

STARTER PROMPT

Read this entire document and flag: (1) any defined term used inconsistently or named two different ways, (2) any cross-references pointing to wrong section numbers, (3) any numbered list with a gap or duplicate number, (4) any formatting that deviates from the rest of the document. Output as a checklist.

8. Draft a report section from source materials

FOR For consultants and researchers

STARTER PROMPT

I will provide three source documents. Synthesise the key findings into a 500-word section for a client report. Use the report's heading style. Structure: finding, supporting evidence, implication. Cite which source each claim comes from. Do not reproduce sentences — paraphrase and synthesise.

9. Improve clarity and conciseness

FOR For anyone tightening a first draft

STARTER PROMPT

Read section 4. It is too verbose and passive. Rewrite it to be 30% shorter, active voice, direct. Keep every substantive point.
Track all changes. After editing, add a comment at the top of the section listing the 3 biggest structural changes you made.

10. Generate a document from a brief

FOR For anyone who needs a first draft from scratch

STARTER PROMPT

I need a 3-page risk assessment memo for a new vendor relationship. Structure: executive summary (one paragraph), vendor background, key commercial risks (minimum 5 risks, each with severity and mitigation), data handling and security assessment, and recommendation. Use my template formatting. Active voice, no jargon.

SECTION 20

Pro Tips, Troubleshooting & First 30 Minutes

Getting the most out of Claude for Word

Pro tips

Always use tracked changes for contracts

Never let Claude make direct edits to a legal document without tracking. Turn it on at the start of every contract session.

Select text before editing it

Claude edits only what you select. For a clause-level edit, select the clause text first, then give the instruction.

Ask for a read before a rewrite

"Summarise what this section is doing" before "rewrite this section" produces better output. Claude needs to understand the logic before preserving it.

Use semantic navigation before searching

"Find every provision touching termination" is faster and more thorough than Ctrl+F. Claude finds thematic matches, not just keyword instances.

Use Opus 4.7 for dense legal material

Switch to Opus 4.7 in the model selector for complex contracts. It handles multi-level numbering and cross-reference dependencies better.

Review before accepting

Tracked changes are tracked but not reviewed. Always read the diff before accepting, especially on counterparty correspondence.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Chat history not saved	By design in beta. Each session starts fresh. Keep context in the document or Instructions.
.doc file not working	Save as .docx first. Word beta only supports .docx.
Claude not tracking changes	Say explicitly: "Make all edits as tracked revisions."
Edits going to wrong place	Select the target text before giving the edit instruction.
Table reflowing after population	Ask Claude to "populate without changing structure or column widths."
iPad not supported	Use Word on web or desktop.

Your first 30 minutes with Claude for Word

1. Open a real document — a contract, memo, or report you are working on. 2. Type: "Read this document and tell me the key themes." 3. Ask: "What are the defined terms and are they used consistently?" 4. Pick one section that needs work. Ask Claude to rewrite it in tracked changes mode. 5. Review the tracked changes. Accept or reject each one. 6. Add what Claude got wrong to Settings → Instructions.

Word Quick Reference

THE MENTAL MODEL	VERSIONS & MODEL
Claude lives in a sidebar inside Word (beta).	Supported: Web · Windows (v2205+) · Mac (v16.61+)
Every edit can land as a tracked revision	NOT supported: iPad · Android · Office 2016/19
in Word’s native review pane — visible,	Separate Marketplace listing from Excel/PPT
reviewable, accept or reject individually.	AVAILABLE MODELS Opus 4.7 · Opus 4.6 · Sonnet 4.6 Use Opus 4.7 for complex legal material
WHAT IT CAN DO	WHAT IT CANNOT DO
Read docs with clickable section citations	Work with .doc files (save as .docx first)
Edit selected text preserving styles	Save chat history between sessions (beta)
Tracked changes mode for all edits	Access Enterprise audit logs currently

THE MENTAL MODEL	VERSIONS & MODEL
Work through comment threads one by one	Replace legal or financial judgment
Summarise counterparty redlines by severity	Final deliverables without human review
Fill templates in your document's styles	Litigation filings without verification
Semantic navigation – thematic, not keyword	

PROMPT FORMULA

[What you want: read / summarise / edit / draft / track changes] + [Which section, clause, or whole doc]
[Mode: tracked changes or direct edit] + [What to preserve: style · structure · defined terms]

HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS

Always say "tracked changes mode" at the start of every contract session – never let Claude make direct unreviewed edits to legal documents
Select the target text before giving an edit instruction – Claude edits only what you have selected, leaving surrounding content untouched
Use Opus 4.7 for dense contracts and multi-level numbered documents – significantly better at preserving cross-references and defined terms

Claude for Outlook
The AI layer for email, calendar, and inbox management

SECTION 21

What Claude for Outlook Is

The add-in for professionals who live in email

What it is

Claude for Outlook (currently in beta) integrates Claude into your Outlook inbox and calendar. It triages your unread mail, drafts replies in your voice, summarises long threads, reads attachments without opening them, finds meeting times, and preps you for calls. Every draft lands unsent in Outlook's native compose pane — Claude never sends on your behalf.

Who it is built for

Deal teams and investment associates

Managing deal flow email, tracking counterparty negotiations, reading attached LOIs and term sheets inline. Claude surfaces what is open, what changed, and what needs a decision.

In-house legal and compliance teams

Contract negotiation threads, counterparty correspondence, document review via email.

Consultants and client-facing professionals

Juggling multiple client threads, scheduling across complex calendars, drafting professional responses at volume. Claude learns your voice from your sent folder.

Managers and executives

Morning inbox triage, scheduling coordination, meeting prep. Claude identifies what needs you and drafts what it can handle.

Anyone with a full inbox

If clearing email takes significant time, Claude can dramatically reduce it — through triage and through faster, better-drafted responses.

SECTION 22

Getting Around Claude for Outlook

The interface, pinning the pane, and what Claude can and cannot do

Opening Claude for Outlook

METHOD	HOW
From the message ribbon	Open any email. Click the Claude button in the message ribbon.
Pin the task pane	Right-click the Claude button → Pin. Stays open as you move between emails.
From Home tab	Add-ins in ribbon → Claude from My Add-ins.

Tip. Pin the Claude pane. Without pinning, the sidebar closes every time you switch emails. Pin it once and it stays open across your entire inbox session. This is the most important setup step.

What Claude can and cannot do in Outlook

CLAUDE CAN	CLAUDE CANNOT
Triage your unread inbox	Send any email or invite on your behalf
Draft replies (unsent, in compose pane)	Access mailboxes you do not have delegate access to
Summarise threads and attachments	Permanently delete emails without your confirmation
Search your mailbox by topic	Access Exchange on-premises (Exchange Online only)
Find free/busy across calendars	Work on iOS or Android Outlook apps
Draft meeting invites (unsent, in appointment form)	—

Microsoft Graph consent – why it matters

Cross-mailbox features – inbox triage, mailbox search, scheduling across calendars – require Microsoft Graph access. Your IT admin must grant this once for your organisation. Per-email features (summarise this email, draft a reply to this email) work without it, but inbox-spanning features do not. If you see a "Need admin approval" message when Claude tries to triage your inbox, send your IT admin to Section 04 of this playbook for the consent steps.

How Claude learns your voice

When drafting replies, Claude reads your sent folder to learn your tone, sentence length, sign-off style, and formality register. The more sent mail it can see, the more accurately it matches your voice. It chooses reply vs reply-all deliberately and warns before adding recipients not on the original thread.

SECTION 23

Key Features in Depth

What Claude for Outlook can actually do

Triage your inbox

Claude reads your unread mail and sorts it into three buckets: action items that need you (each with a one-line reason), items Claude can handle (pre-drafted for your review), and noise you can archive in one click.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What needs me this morning?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Draft replies for everything you can handle"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Archive all calendar responses and newsletter emails"

Draft replies in your voice

Tell Claude what you want to say and it drafts the reply into Outlook's native compose pane, unsent. Tone learned from your sent folder.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Reply and agree to the extension, but push back on the fee"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Reply-all confirming Thursday works"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Forward to Dana with a two-line summary of what she needs to know"

Summarise long threads

Claude reads the full thread – every reply and forward – and tells you what has been decided, what is open, and who owes what. Every claim cites the specific email it came from.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What has been decided and what is still open?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Who owes what on this thread?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Give me a one-paragraph summary of this 47-email thread"

Read attachments inline

Claude reads .docx, .xlsx, .pptx, and .pdf attachments without you opening them.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What changed in the attached LOI?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Summarise the attached deck"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What are the headline numbers in the attached financial model?"

Search your mailbox

Find past conversations by topic, not just keywords. Results are clickable citations that open the source message.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"When did we last discuss the cap with Fernwood?"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Find the email where Dana sent the revised term sheet"

Find time and create meeting invites

Claude checks free/busy for everyone whose calendar you can see and proposes slots. The invite is drafted in Outlook's native appointment form — you review and send.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Find 30 minutes with Dana and the Fernwood team next week"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Block Thursday afternoon for deep work"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Add an agenda to my Thursday team meeting"

Prep for meetings

For your next event, Claude pulls the last thread with each attendee and any attached documents into a one-page brief.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Prep me for my 2pm with the Fernwood team"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"What is open with each attendee before this meeting?"

Cross-app context

Claude for Outlook shares context with Word, Excel, and PowerPoint.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Open the attached contract in Word with this thread as context"

EXAMPLE PROMPT

"Pull the figures from this email into the open Excel model"

SECTION 24

10 Use Cases with Starter Prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Claude for Outlook

1. Morning inbox triage

FOR For anyone whose inbox is already full before 9am

STARTER PROMPT

What needs me this morning? Sort my unread emails into three groups: (1) things needing a decision or action from me today, (2) things you can draft replies for without my input, (3) noise I can archive. For group 1, give me a one-line reason why it needs me. For group 2, draft the replies unsent. For group 3, archive in one click.

2. Summarise a long deal thread

FOR For deal teams managing high-volume counterparty email

STARTER PROMPT

Read the entire Fernwood thread. Tell me: what has been agreed, what is still open, what each side is pushing for, and what the next step is. For each claim, cite which email it came from. I need to be briefed in 90 seconds.

3. Draft a negotiation reply

FOR For anyone managing a commercial or legal negotiation by email

STARTER PROMPT

Read the latest email in this thread. They are pushing back on our payment terms, asking for 90-day payment. Draft a reply that:
acknowledges their position, holds our position at 45 days, proposes a compromise (60 days for orders over a defined threshold),
and keeps the tone collaborative. Land it unsent. Match my usual voice.

4. Read an attachment without opening it

FOR For anyone triaging attached documents before deciding whether to open them

STARTER PROMPT

Read the attached LOI. Tell me: the key commercial terms, anything that deviates from what we discussed on the call last week,
and the 2-3 things I should push back on before signing. I need this in 3 minutes.

5. Find time across complex calendars

FOR For anyone managing schedules across multiple stakeholders

STARTER PROMPT

I need to schedule a 60-minute call with Dana, James from Fernwood, and my associate Sarah. Find three options next week that
work for all of us during business hours. Draft the invite with a clear agenda: status update, open items, decision needed on
pricing. Land it unsent.

6. Prep for a high-stakes meeting

FOR For anyone walking into a call they have not had time to prepare for

STARTER PROMPT

I have a call with the Fernwood team in 45 minutes. Pull the last 5 threads I have had with any Fernwood team member. Read any attached documents. Tell me: what has been agreed, what is open, what each person last said, and the 3 things most likely to come up. One page maximum.

7. Clear a backlog of pending replies

FOR For anyone with a pile of emails waiting for a response

STARTER PROMPT

I have 12 emails flagged for reply. For each one, draft a response based on the thread context. Land each draft unsent in my compose pane. Where the reply requires a decision from me, leave a **[DECISION NEEDED: brief question]** placeholder. Work through all 12.

8. Search for a specific past agreement

FOR For anyone trying to track down something discussed months ago

STARTER PROMPT

Find every email where I or anyone on my team discussed the Oakwood acquisition timeline. I think the decision was made in Q1 but I cannot find the thread. Search by topic, not just keywords. For each result: date, sender, and a one-line summary. Cite the source emails.

9. Weekly email review and housekeeping

FOR For anyone who wants to start each week with a clean inbox

STARTER PROMPT

It is Monday morning. Read my inbox from last week. Summarise: what was resolved, what is still open, threads where I have not replied but should have, and commitments I made that I have not followed up on. Archive resolved threads, flag ones with open actions, and draft a reply for any thread where I am overdue.

10. Handle a scheduling pile-up

FOR For anyone with multiple scheduling requests at once

STARTER PROMPT

I have several emails trying to schedule calls with me. Read them all. For each one, draft a polite reply with three time options from my available slots next week. If the same slot is proposed to multiple people, flag the conflict. Land all drafts unsent.

SECTION 25

Pro Tips, Troubleshooting & First 30 Minutes

Getting the most out of Claude for Outlook

Pro tips

Pin the task pane

Without pinning, the sidebar closes every time you switch emails. Pin it once and it stays open. Most important setup step.

Never assume Claude sent anything

Claude drafts, you send. Always check the compose pane before clicking send, especially for reply-alls and external correspondence.

Triage before reading individually

Let Claude triage first thing in the morning before you start reading. It reframes your inbox from a pile into a prioritised list.

Use it for attachments you dread opening

Long PDF reports, dense spreadsheets, multi-redline contracts — ask Claude to summarise the attachment before deciding whether to open it.

Prep for every important call

Before any significant call, ask Claude to pull the last three threads with each attendee. Takes 30 seconds and consistently surfaces things you had forgotten.

Get the Graph consent step done

If cross-mailbox features are not working, the issue is almost always the Microsoft Graph consent. Send your IT admin to Section 04.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
"Need admin approval" on inbox features	IT admin needs to grant Microsoft Graph consent. See Section 04.
Claude button not in ribbon	Open any email first – button only appears in message ribbon when an email is open.
Drafts not appearing	Check your Drafts folder. All Claude drafts land there, unsent.
Claude not matching my tone	Ask Claude to read 10-20 sent emails and note your patterns before drafting.
Attachment not being read	Supported: .docx, .xlsx, .pptx, .pdf. Other formats not supported inline.
iOS/Android not working	Outlook on iOS and Android not supported. Use web or desktop.

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Exchange on-premises not working	Requires Exchange Online (Microsoft 365). On-premises Exchange not supported.

Your first 30 minutes with Claude for Outlook

1. Install the add-in. Open any email. Click Claude and sign in. 2. Pin the task pane immediately. 3. Type: "What needs me this morning?" Read the triage output. 4. Pick one email where Claude offered to draft a reply. Review the draft. 5. Edit the draft to match your voice better. Note what to add to Instructions.

6. Open Settings → Instructions. Add 3 lines: tone preference, sign-off, one thing Claude must never do. 7. Second session: ask Claude to prep you for your next calendar event.

Tip. The first triage will not be perfect — Claude is reading your inbox cold. After two or three sessions, once it has seen your sent patterns and your instructions, the output will be significantly better.

Outlook Quick Reference

THE MENTAL MODEL	VERSIONS & REQUIREMENTS
Claude lives in a sidebar inside Outlook (beta).	Supported: Web · Windows (new + classic) · Mac
It drafts – you send. Every reply and invite	NOT supported: iOS · Android · Exchange on-prem
lands unsent in the native compose pane.	Separate Marketplace listing from Excel/PPT/Word
Claude never sends anything on your behalf.	GRAPH CONSENT (admin, one-time) Required for inbox triage and search Scopes: Mail.ReadWrite · Calendars.Read People.Read · User.Read · offline_access
WHAT IT CAN DO	WHAT IT CANNOT DO
Triage unread inbox into 3 buckets	Send email or invites without your review
Draft replies in your voice from sent folder	Access mailboxes without delegate permission
Summarise threads with per-email citations	Work on iOS, Android, or Exchange on-prem

THE MENTAL MODEL	VERSIONS & REQUIREMENTS
Read .docx .xlsx .pptx .pdf attachments inline	Triage inbox without IT admin Graph consent
Search mailbox by topic, not just keywords	Access Enterprise audit logs currently (beta)
Find free/busy and draft meeting invites	Replace judgment on relationship management
Prep meeting briefs from recent threads	

PROMPT FORMULA

[What you want: triage / draft / summarise / find time / prep / search] + [Scope: this email · thread · inbox · date range]
[Tone and reply format if drafting] + [What to exclude or watch out for]

HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS
Pin the Claude task pane immediately – without pinning, the sidebar closes every time you switch emails; pin it once and it stays
open all session
Complete the IT admin Microsoft Graph consent step (Section 04) – without this, inbox triage, search, and scheduling do not work
Set persistent Instructions: tone preference, sign-off style, one thing Claude must never do in email – shapes every draft it produces

SECTION 26

Quick Reference Card

Everything you need in one place

EXCEL	POWERPOINT
Finance, FP&A, data analysis, modeling	Slide decks, pitch materials, reports
Reads formulas and multi-tab workbooks	Builds from your template and slide master
Cell-level citations and change tracking	Edits individual slides without redoing deck
Builds, fills, debugs spreadsheets	Native charts and diagrams (editable)
Ctrl+Alt+C / Ctrl+Option+C to open	Ctrl+Alt+C / Ctrl+Option+C to open
WORD (BETA)	OUTLOOK (BETA)
Contracts, memos, reports, documents	Email triage, replies, scheduling

EXCEL	POWERPOINT
Tracked changes mode for every edit	Drafts land unsent – you click send
Works through comment threads	Reads attachments inline
Semantic navigation across provisions	Finds meeting times cross-calendar
Reads counterparty redlines	Requires Graph consent for inbox features
PLANS & VERSIONS	INSTALL
Pro, Max, Team, Enterprise – all supported	Excel+PPT+Word: one listing on M365 Marketplace
Free plan: none of the four add-ins	Outlook: separate listing on M365 Marketplace
Active Microsoft 365 subscription required	Admin deploy via Microsoft 365 Admin Center
Office 2016/2019 perpetual: not supported	Or manifest XML for orgs with Store disabled

EXCEL	POWERPOINT
Mobile apps: not supported	Outlook needs one-time Graph consent from admin
CROSS-APP	SAFETY
All four share context in one session	Data deleted from Anthropic servers in 30 days
Enable: Settings → Let Claude work across files	Chat history stored locally, not synced
Team/Enterprise: admin enables org-wide first	No HIPAA, PCI, or SOX compliance
Skills apply per app automatically	No audit logs on Pro/Max/Team plans
All four must be installed and active	Never use with untrusted external files

Prompt formula – all four add-ins

EXCEL

[What you want: read, build, fix, update, analyse]. [Which cells, tabs, or ranges]. [Output format: table, chart, new tab, edited in place]. [Formatting convention if different from your Instructions].

POWERPOINT

[What you want: generate, edit, restructure, convert to visual]. [Which slides or the whole deck]. [Audience and purpose: board deck, internal update, client pitch]. [Brand or formatting constraints].

WORD

[What you want: read, summarise, edit, draft, track changes]. [Which section, clause, or whole document]. [Mode: tracked changes or direct edit]. [What to preserve: style, structure, defined terms].

OUTLOOK

[What you want: triage, draft, summarise, find time, prep, search]. [Scope: this email, thread, inbox, or date range]. [Tone and reply format if drafting]. [What to exclude or watch out for].

Highest-leverage setup steps — all four add-ins

- Set persistent Instructions in each add-in — 10 minutes per tool, every future session benefits.
- Enable cross-app in Settings and activate the add-in in each app at least once.
- For Outlook: get your IT admin to complete the Microsoft Graph consent step (Section 04).
- For Excel: enable session logging for any complex modeling session.
- For Word: start every contract session by asking Claude to read and summarise before editing.
- For PowerPoint: always load your template before starting a Claude session.

END OF PLAYBOOK

Your turning point starts here.